

K. RAMMOHAN NAIDU
Union Minister of Civil Aviation



KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **High airfares, price surges are sensitive issues—demand is greater than available aircraft. So once planes are increased, prices will go down**
- **Delhi is to be an aviation hub—connected to important cities, following a hub and spoke model**
- **Digi Yatra has been a success; passports are being brought into it to make international travel easier**
- **More investors are being encouraged to enter the Flight Training Organisation sector**

This year's edition of the India Today Infrastructure Conclave came at a time when the Modi government reiterated its commitment to infrastructure as a catalyst for Viksit Bharat by 2047. But the challenge, as usual, comes from implementation. Experts not only discussed the milestones the country covered in its quest to boost infrastructure, but also the areas where we fell short and the remedies.

The tone for the conclave was set by Union civil aviation minister K. Rammohan Naidu, who highlighted the Centre's major reforms, ranging from developing aviation hubs—in New Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad—to digital technology that's made flying a lot easier. "We are up to the mark when it comes to Asian countries.... But by global standards, we have to make a lot more progress," he said.

Meanwhile, Pieter Elbers, CEO of IndiGo Airlines, outlined his vision for the airline. He said that international travel presented a great opportunity, and India needed to start building on that. On competition from Air India, Elbers said the country needed multiple airlines. "The issue is not, 'I have 400 and you have 200'. The issue is if you want to compete with them (international carriers), you need a global footprint. You need to partner with others.... Indigo is building that," he said.

Sarbananda Sonowal, Union minister of ports, shipping and waterways, said Indian ports are competing with global leaders, with turnaround times surpassing Australia, the US and Germany. Modernisation through AI-driven logistics and digital integration is making them more competitive, he said.

Experts from the aviation and shipping sectors discussed specific issues. Other sessions on removing financial roadblocks, tenacity of India's growth story and the need to maintain sustainable infrastructure contributed to the comprehensive character of the conclave. ■ **– M.G. Arun**